

SI-MI: Social Identity Matters in Mentoring

Session 5: Color-Evasive Practices

Guiding question: How do color-evasive practices show up in mentoring, and how can mentors move toward more race-conscious and accountable approaches?

Overview: This session explores color-evasive language and practices and how they can obscure or minimize racial realities in academic settings. Participants will consider how these patterns show up in mentoring and will reflect on how more race-conscious, responsive approaches can better support students of color.

Objectives:

- Identify examples of color-evasive language, behavior, and assumptions.
- Understand how these practices can affect mentees and perpetuate inequity.
- Reflect on how mentoring responses can move from avoidance toward greater racial awareness and accountability.

Before the Session: Complete the assigned videos and reflection exercise before the session. Come ready to discuss how common statements or assumptions can overlook racial context and how those patterns may affect mentoring.

- **Watch:** TED Talk: [Color Blind or Color Brave?](#) by Mellody Hobson
 - **Note:** Since 2014, the ableist term “color blind” has been replaced by “color evasive.”
- **Watch:** [Color Evasiveness](#) by Angela Davis
- **Reflect:**
 - Consider the following statements. How does each statement lack a racial awareness lens? What are the potential effects of these statements on students of color? For each statement, what situation is more likely to be true?
 - **Statement A:** “I think if students of color just felt more confident and asked for help, they would be fine.”
 - **Statement B:** “In some communities, families just don't have the same love of science.”
 - **Statement C:** “It's not racial, it's about students who are from low-income schools that are underprepared.”

What to Expect in the Live Session: The live session will include group discussion, breakout conversations, and broad application of the week's ideas to mentoring contexts. Participants should expect to analyze examples, reflect on their own practice, and consider how to respond more thoughtfully in racially charged situations.

Takeaways:

- Color-evasive language can unintentionally dismiss or obscure mentees' lived experiences.
- Avoiding conversations about race can reinforce inequities rather than prevent harm
- Becoming more race-conscious requires reflection, discomfort, and intentional practice.